With Xi’s ascent to the leadership of the Communist Party and the Chinese presidency, there has been an exacerbation along all of these trends. China’s governance has become even more centralized and opaque, the economy has become less market-oriented and more state-controlled, territorial disputes are being more forcefully dealt with, and international norms are being more obviously trampled upon. Even as China benefits from other countries’ relatively open economies and political systems, it places restrictions on businesses, educational institutions, media distribution, and political engagement by others in its own country.

Although these attributes have elicited broader concerns about China’s rise and behaviour, there are certain specific reasons for India’s heightened threat perception. In fact, it is useful to think of India–China relations along four dimensions. The first is bilateral security, mostly related to the border dispute. China’s ability to mobilize its military on the border has improved significantly, and it has periodically attempted to change the status quo as during the 1950s, the 1980s, and after 2013. When challenged by Indian patrols, Beijing selectively interprets past legal treaties and agreements, conveniently ignoring those that do not support its case. Its actions in 2020 violated almost three decades of written agreements with India, severely setting back trust. The second element is regional security, where the differences are even wider. India harbours deep distrust of China’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), which it assesses to be a strategic project designed to offer easy financing to vulnerable economies, with the resulting debt being leveraged for political or strategic gain. That the BRI is a unilateral project that also violates Indian territory (by traversing Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir) contributes to Indian resistance. [13] The third element concerns bilateral economic relations, where the trade deficit remained in China’s favour. While previously optimistic about prospects of economic relations with China, Indian business is increasingly concerned that China does not offer a level playing field in areas where India enjoys comparative advantages. Furthermore, in many areas of emerging technology, the prospect of cooperation with China exposes India to critical vulnerabilities. The fourth area concerns global governance, where India and China have